unknown facts. In the media, free competition means that if one outlet decides not to break a scandal, perhaps for self-serving reasons, others are likely to jump at the scoop. In the judiciary, a judge who takes bribes may be tried and punished just like any other citizen.

Second, the existence of several independent institutions that seek the truth in different ways allows these institutions to check and correct one another. For example, if powerful corporations manage to break down the peer-review mechanism by bribing a sufficiently large number of scientists, investigative journalists and courts can expose and punish the perpetrators. If the media or the courts are afflicted by systematic racist biases, it is the job of sociologists, historians and philosophers to expose those biases. None of these mechanisms are completely fail-safe, but no human institution is. Government certainly isn't.

THE POPULIST ASSAULT

If all this sounds complicated, it is because democracy *should* be complicated. Simplicity is a characteristic of dictatorial information networks in which the centre dictates everything and everybody silently obeys. It's easy to follow this dictatorial monologue. In contrast, democracy is a conversation with numerous participants, many of them talking at the same time. It can be hard to follow such a conversation.

Moreover, the most important democratic institutions tend to be bureaucratic behemoths. Whereas citizens avidly follow the biographical dramas of the princely court and the presidential palace, they often find it difficult to understand how parliaments, courts, newspapers and universities function. This is what helps strongmen mount populist attacks on institutions, dismantle all self-correcting mechanisms and concentrate power in their own hands. We discussed populism briefly in the prologue, to help explain the populist challenge to the naive view of information. Here we need to revisit populism, get a broader understanding of its worldview and explain its appeal to antidemocratic strongmen.

The term 'populism' derives from the Latin *populus*, which means 'the people'. In democracies, 'the people' is considered the sole legitimate source of political authority. Only representatives of the people should have the authority to declare wars, pass laws and raise taxes. Populists cherish